

“anti-Nebraska” group included Free-Soilers, abolitionists, and Northern Whigs. Yet, despite an outcry across the North, Douglas was able to convince and coerce enough Senate Democrats to approve the Kansas-Nebraska Act—15 of the 20 Northern Democrats supported it. In the House, where Southern influence was weaker, it just barely passed. In the elections that followed, half of the incumbent Northern Democrats lost their seats.

The way was now open to let the settlers vote. Neighboring Missouri, a slave state, encouraged a first wave of pro-slavery migrants, but as 1854 went on, anti-slavery settlers from across the North and Midwest entered the territory. Missouri politicians helped organize militia and citizens’ groups prepared to ride into the state’s border regions to scare Northern or free-state advocates. The Missourians also voted illegally, hoping to elect delegates who would support slavery.

Atchison personally led a large group of “Border Ruffians”—as the Missouri citizens were called by abolitionists—across the Kansas state line to vote. He boasted that 1,100 people were on the way and he could gather another 5,000 if needed. The count for the first territorial legislature included those 5,000 fraudulent tallies and resulted in a pro-slavery body. The territorial governor begged President Franklin Pierce to invalidate the election, but Pierce, a political ally of Atchison, fired the governor instead.

1,000 The approximate number of Sharps rifles that were smuggled to anti-slavery fighters in Kansas during the period of bitter conflict between 1854 and 1858.

JAYHAWKER An anti-slavery guerrilla from Kansas. Named after a make-believe bird, the Jayhawkers clashed with Missouri’s Border Ruffians. Both sides terrorized the residents of Missouri and Kansas.